Be Angry, and Sin Not

Anger itself is not always sin, but we must deal with it quickly, put away bitterness, and replace it with the kindness and forgiveness God has shown us.

Main passage	Ephesians 4:25-32 (KJV)
Topic	Anger
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Anger must be handled quickly	7 min
Teaching point 2: Put away bitterness and harmful words	7 min
Teaching point 3: Replace it with kindness and forgiveness	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "What makes you angry?" Let people answer lightly (traffic, being kept waiting, injustice, being ignored). Then ask: "Is anger always wrong?" Let the class discuss briefly before reading. Many are surprised to find a verse that says, "Be ye angry."

Scripture (3 min)

Ephesians 4:25-32

25 Wherefore putting away lying, speak every man truth with his neighbour: for we are members one of
another. 26 Be ye angry, and sin not: let not the sun go down upon your wrath: 27 Neither give place to the
devil. 28 Let him that stole steal no more: but rather let him labour, working with his hands the thing which is
good, that he may have to give to him that needeth. 29 Let no corrupt communication proceed out of your
mouth, but that which is good to the use of edifying, that it may minister grace unto the hearers. 30 And

grieve not the holy Spirit of God, whereby ye are sealed unto the day of redemption. [31] Let all bitterness, and wrath, and anger, and clamour, and evil speaking, be put away from you, with all malice: [32] And be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you.

Read the passage aloud.

Background (5 min)

Ephesians 4-6 turns from doctrine to daily life. Paul has just told believers to "put off ... the old man" and "put on the new man" (4:22-24). Now he shows what that looks like in speech, work and relationships. Each command has a reason attached: we are members of one another (v. 25); do not give the devil a foothold (v. 27); share with those in need (v. 28); do not grieve the Holy Spirit (v. 30); forgive as God forgave you (v. 32).

"Be ye angry, and sin not" quotes Psalm 4:4. Jesus himself was angry at hardness of heart (Mark 3:5) and at those who turned the temple into a marketplace (John 2:13-17).

Teaching point 1: Anger must be handled quickly (7 min)

There is a right anger, at injustice and sin, like Christ's own. But even right anger easily turns into sin. Paul gives a practical rule: "let not the sun go down upon your wrath." Anger that is kept overnight hardens into resentment, and that gives the devil a foothold.

Supporting verses

Ephesians 4:26-27: Be ye angry, and sin not: let not the sun go down upon your wrath: Neither give place to the devil.

Mark 3:5: And when he had looked round about on them with anger, being grieved for the hardness of their hearts, he saith unto the man, Stretch forth thine hand. And he stretched it out: and his hand was restored whole as the other.

James 1:19-20: Wherefore, my beloved brethren, let every man be swift to hear, slow to speak, slow to wrath: For the wrath of man worketh not the righteousness of God.

> *"Should circumstances arise to call for anger on your part, let it be as Christ's "anger" (Mr 3:5), without sin."*
>
> — Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Ephesians 4:26

> *"The keeping of anger through the darkness of night, is giving place to the devil, the prince of darkness"*
>
> — Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Ephesians 4:27

Handout blanks (answers)

Be ye angry, and **sin** not.

Let not the **sun** go down upon your wrath.

Teaching point 2: Put away bitterness and harmful words (7 min)

Verses 29-31 list what has to go: corrupt speech, bitterness, wrath, anger, clamour (shouting), evil speaking and malice. In their place: words that build up and give grace to those who hear. Paul adds a tender warning: "grieve not the holy Spirit of God." Our unkind words do not just hurt people; they grieve God, who lives in us.

Supporting verses

Ephesians 4:29-31: Let no corrupt communication proceed out of your mouth, but that which is good to the use of edifying, that it may minister grace unto the hearers. And grieve not the holy Spirit of God, whereby ye are sealed unto the day of redemption. Let all bitterness, and wrath, and anger, and clamour, and evil speaking, be put away from you, with all malice:

Proverbs 15:1: A soft answer turneth away wrath: but grievous words stir up anger.

Colossians 3:8: But now ye also put off all these; anger, wrath, malice, blasphemy, filthy communication out of your mouth.

> *"It is astonishing that any who profess the Christian name should indulge bitterness of spirit."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Ephesians 4:31

> *"This is addressed to Christians, and it proves that it is possible for them to grieve the Holy Spirit."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Ephesians 4:30

Handout blanks (answers)

Let no **corrupt** communication proceed out of your mouth.

Grieve not the holy **Spirit** of God.

Teaching point 3: Replace it with kindness and forgiveness (7 min)

Paul does not only say "stop"; he says "start." "Be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you" (v. 32). The cure for bitterness is not just suppressing anger; it is remembering how much God has forgiven us, and passing that forgiveness on.

Supporting verses

Ephesians 4:32: And be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you.

Colossians 3:12-13: Put on therefore, as the elect of God, holy and beloved, bowels of mercies, kindness, humbleness of mind, meekness, longsuffering; Forbearing one another, and forgiving one another, if any man have a quarrel against any: even as Christ forgave you, so also do ye.

Matthew 6:14-15: For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you: But if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.

> *"it is but just that you in turn shall be so to your fellow men"*

— Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Ephesians 4:32

"Christianity produces true courteousness, or politeness."
— Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Ephesians 4:32

Handout blanks (answers)

Be ye kind one to another, **tenderhearted**, forgiving one another.

Forgive even as God for Christ's sake hath **forgiven** you.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. What is the difference between righteous anger and sinful anger?

Righteous anger is directed at real wrong, seeks good, and is under control; sinful anger is selfish, harms others, and is nursed.

2. Why do you think Paul says not to let the sun go down on our anger?

Unresolved anger hardens into bitterness and resentment and gives the devil opportunity.

3. Which item in verse 31 is the hardest for you to put away?

Answers will vary.

4. How does remembering God's forgiveness help us forgive others?

We have been forgiven far more than anyone owes us (compare the parable in Matthew 18:21-35).

Application (3 min)

If you are carrying anger toward someone, settle it before the sun goes down: pray about it today, and take one step toward peace if it is safe and wise. Before you speak in a tense moment this week, ask: "Will this build up, or tear down?"

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord, you know our tempers and our grudges. Forgive us for anger that has turned into sin, for bitter words and for the times we have grieved your Holy Spirit. Make us kind, tenderhearted and forgiving, as you have forgiven us for Christ's sake. Help us settle our anger before the sun goes down. Amen.

Sources quoted

Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Ephesians 4:26

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